

DUSTCLOUDS TDP workers in Prakasam protest illegal sand mining

ANDHRA PRADESH

CAUGHT IN A SANDSTORM

By Amarnath K. Menon

With the Andhra Pradesh assembly polls less than a year away, Telugu Desam Party (TDP) chief N. Chandrababu Naidu has stepped up his attacks on the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP). The latest in that series of volleys is an alleged sand mining scam, an issue that keeps rearing its ugly head every few years in the state. Naidu has alleged that under the tacit support of chief minister Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy, the sand mafia in the state has earned a whopping Rs 40,000 crore through illegal mining. On August 28, three days after Naidu claimed that he had evidence to support his claim, his party workers staged a statewide protest and identified 67 quarries where norms were being violated. The demonstrations eventually led to as many as 11 FIRs and over a hundred TDP leaders and cadres getting booked.

The TDP claims that YSRCP leaders have not only become 'wholesale dealers' of sand and minor minerals, but that the government has also ignored the directives of the National Green Tribunal (NGT) and the Supreme Court. On July 14 this year, the top court refused to annul a ban on sand mining imposed by the NGT in 2022. The SC ruling had come as a major blow to the Andhra Pradesh government. "The stay imposed by the NGT, especially on mechanised mining, and the apex court's refusal to override the NGT order, vindicates the TDP's stand," Naidu told media last month. "Though there were only 110 sanctioned sand reaches in the state, mining continues unabated from more than 500 illegal ones," he said, adding that under the YSRCP, nearly 400 million tonnes of sand was mined illegally. Further, he said, nearly 4 million construction workers lost their livelihood after the YSRCP government cancelled the free sand policy introduced during the TDP's tenure in 2016, under which only transport and loading costs were passed on to buyers.

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Upon taking charge as chief minister in 2019, Jagan withdrew the policy and introduced a fresh scheme, under which the state-owned AP Mineral Development Corporation Ltd (APMDC) would undertake quarrying and supply on behalf of the government, and the price of sand was fixed at Rs 375 per tonne. What raises questions, though, was the fact that the YSRCP govern-